

BACK FOOT PLAY
CM Mamata Banerjee also holds the home portfolio in Bengal

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HANSKHALI RAPE

TEMPER OVER DIDI'S INTEMPERANCE

By Romita Datta

In a state where even minor mistakes by politicians are seized upon by adversaries and blown up as far as they would go, this was a misstep that invited condemnation. So much so that the shrill cries of castigation by the Opposition had to be tempered by critical voices from the party under attack.

The alleged gangrape and murder of a 14-year-old Class 9 student at Hanskhali, Nadia, around 100 km from Kolkata, on April 4, had sent shockwaves across the state. The girl had gone to attend the birthday party of the 21-year-old main accused, Brajagopal Gayali, alias Sohail, who was arrested after an FIR was filed on April 10. Sohail was the son of gram panchayat member and local Trinamool Congress heavyweight Samar Gayali.

However, speaking at a state government event on April 11 in the presence of state police chief Manoj Malaviya, West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee wondered if the incident could be called a rape. "I condemn the incident...but I heard there was a love affair between the boy and the girl. Was it an actual rape, love affair, a case of pregnancy or any other reason?"

As expected, Bengal's otherwise beleaguered Opposition trained their guns at the CM in a trice. BJP's Suvendu Adhikary, Leader of Opposition in the assembly, asked people to "rethink whom they've voted to power". Senior CPI(M) leader Sujan Chakraborty called it "unfortunate" and Congress's Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury cuttingly remarked, "Does this victim not fall under the TMC's Maa, Mati, Manush governance?" All of them suspected the CM was trying to shield a party member from the law.

The Opposition's shows of denunciation at the outrage and the CM's reaction to it are one matter; many citizens are deeply dismayed by the turn of affairs. Not only has there been a string of rape cases reported in Bengal in recent times, the accused in almost all of these are allegedly from the ruling TMC.

Yet, prima facie, the state police probe into the Hanskhali gangrape wasn't hushed up. After the victim died of excessive bleeding on April 5, she was hastily cremated in an alleged move to destroy evidence. Moreover, her parents lodged a police complaint only on April 10, five days after the girl's death. Her father alleged that the accused forced them into the hasty cremation. The matter came to light after a BSF personnel with BJP leanings apparently convinced them to file a complaint. After his arrest, Sohail was sent to 14-day judicial custody.

What drove Mamata to those remarks was, say political observers, the Opposition's continual linking of the alleged crime to the TMC. "She's always smelling a political conspiracy and thus combative. Sometimes she says things that she later regrets, but by then the damage has been done," says social scientist Prasanta Ray. A TMC insider concurs. "The TMC is one big family for her.... She's unsparing towards any offence and corruption, but doesn't like her family being criticised by the Opposition," he says. The nearest Mamata would get to publicly admit a faux pas came on the eve of the Bengali New Year on April 14, during a visit to the Kalighat temple in Kolkata. She had come to pray, she said, so that good sense and humanism prevail. "Politics aside, I am, after all, a human being...," she said.

Most people in Bengal would have instantly connected Mamata's Hanskhali remarks to those she